MADURAI AIRPORT · IXM / VOMD

Ten years of traffic – and how Madurai can catch up

Review of FY 2016-17 to FY 2026-27 (to Sep 26) with recommendations for authorities and airlines

Data: AAI (124 months), AeroDataBox (95 days of flights) · 2026-11-01

Executive summary

13.9 lakh

passengers in FY 2025-26

-8.7% vs FY18-19 peak

+21.9%

all-India growth, same period

FY18-19 to FY25-26

#32 → #40

Madurai's national rank

by passengers

−59,923

international passengers lost

Mar–Jul 2026 vs 2025 (Gulf suspension)

- Madurai is the only airport in its peer group still below its pre-COVID peak; Trichy grew +40.7% and now carries 1.6× Madurai's traffic.
- Had Madurai grown like India since FY18-19 it would handle about 18.5 lakh passengers a year – roughly 4.6 lakh more than today.
- The data point to airline capacity and connectivity, not the terminal, as the constraint: about 48% of the 2.9 million annual capacity is used and the busiest hour averages only 4.4–5.0 movements a day.
- Priorities: restore and widen Gulf links, use the new international status to bring in foreign airlines, upgauge Chennai/Bengaluru from turboprops, use night slots, attract a second airline.

What this analysis is built on – and how it was checked

AAI official traffic

- 124 monthly reports, Apr 16 – Sep 26
- Passengers (domestic/international), aircraft movements, cargo tonnes
- 8 complete financial years (2017-18 to 2024-25) add up exactly to AAI's published annual totals
- Not published / not found: 2016-10, 2025-11

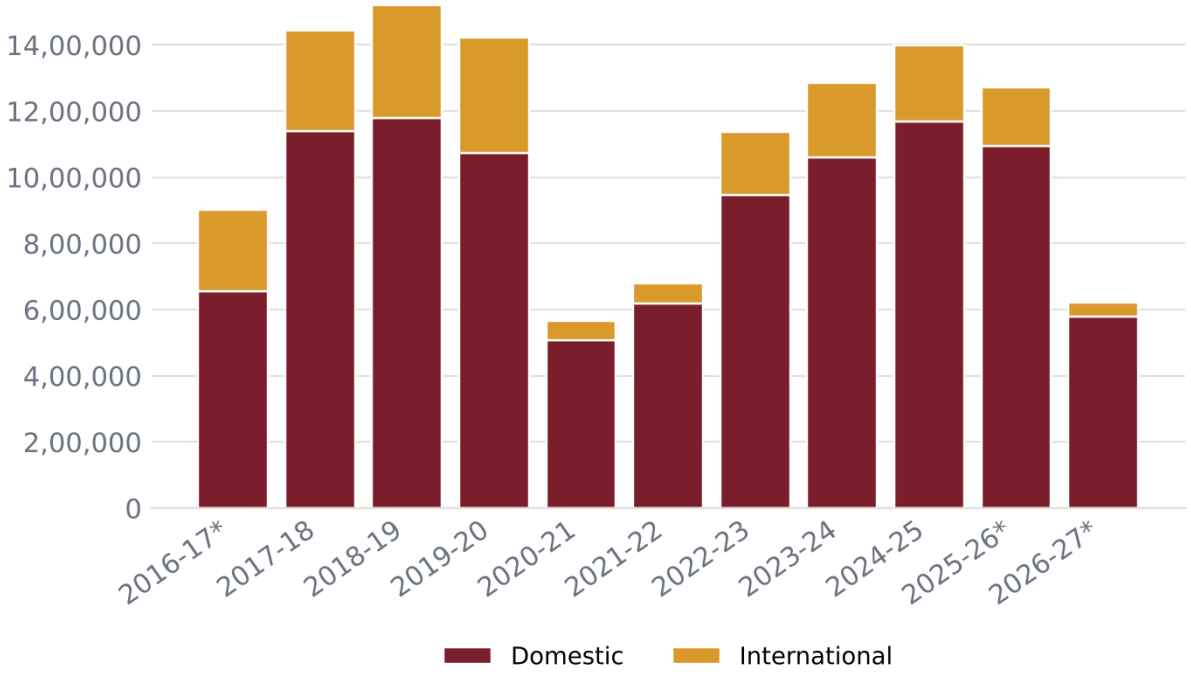
AeroDataBox flight records

- 95 days of individual flights (airline, route, aircraft, times)
- Jan 26: 776 flights vs 801 AAI movements (96.9%)
- Jun 26: 1,114 flights vs 1,128 AAI movements (98.8%)
- Only months with complete daily data are used for network analysis

Published context

- Peer airports & all-India totals: AAI figures via Wikipedia
- Infrastructure & policy: Ministry replies, news reports (dated, listed in the Excel)
- Scenarios are what-if paths, not forecasts

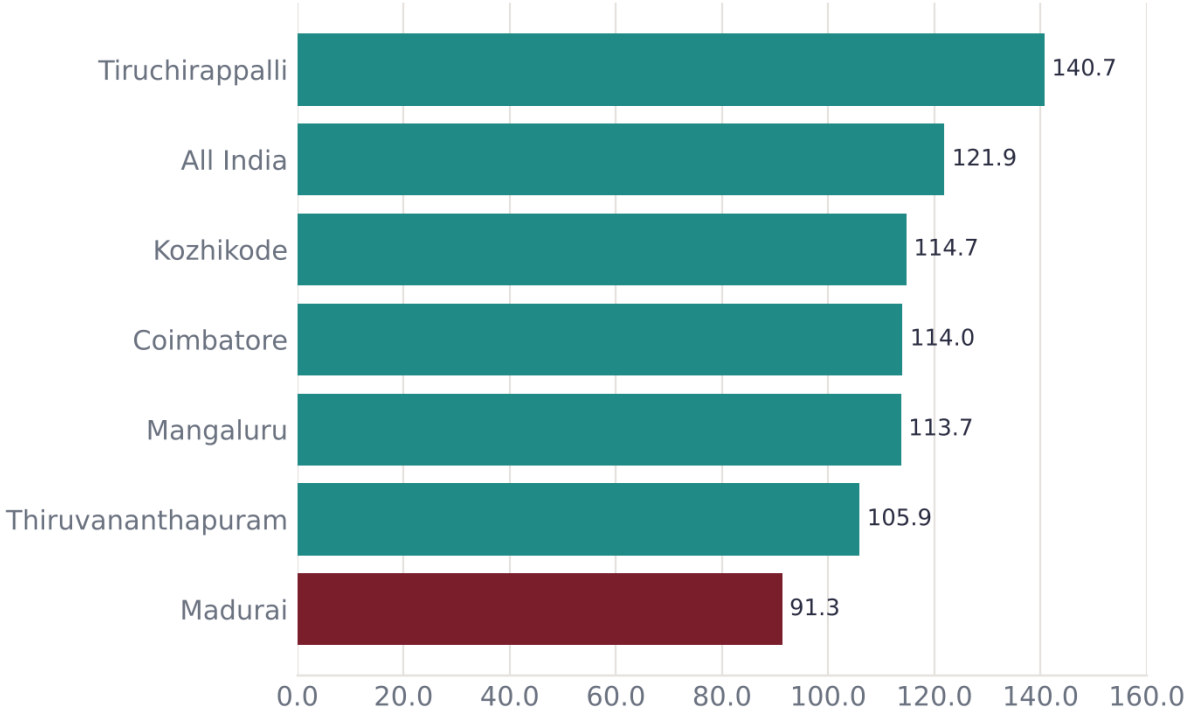
Ten years of passengers: a pre-COVID peak not yet regained



- Peak: 15,20,016 in FY 2018-19
- COVID low: 5,65,539 in FY 2020-21 (37% of peak)
- Best since: 13,99,046 in FY 2024-25 (92% of peak)
- FY 2025-26: 13,88,062 (published total; −0.8%)
- * partial year: FY16-17 (Oct 2016 missing), FY25-26 (Nov 2025 missing), FY26-27 (Apr–Sep)

Source: AAI monthly Traffic News (aai.aero), compiled by the IXM Pulse tracker

Peers grew past pre-COVID levels – Madurai did not



- Index: FY 2025-26 passengers as % of FY 2018-19 (last full pre-COVID year)
- Madurai 91.3 – the only one below 100
- All India 121.9; Trichy 140.7
- Madurai's annual change: -1.29% a year vs India +2.87%

Source: AAI annual figures as tabulated on Wikipedia 'List of busiest airports in India' (verify before quoting)

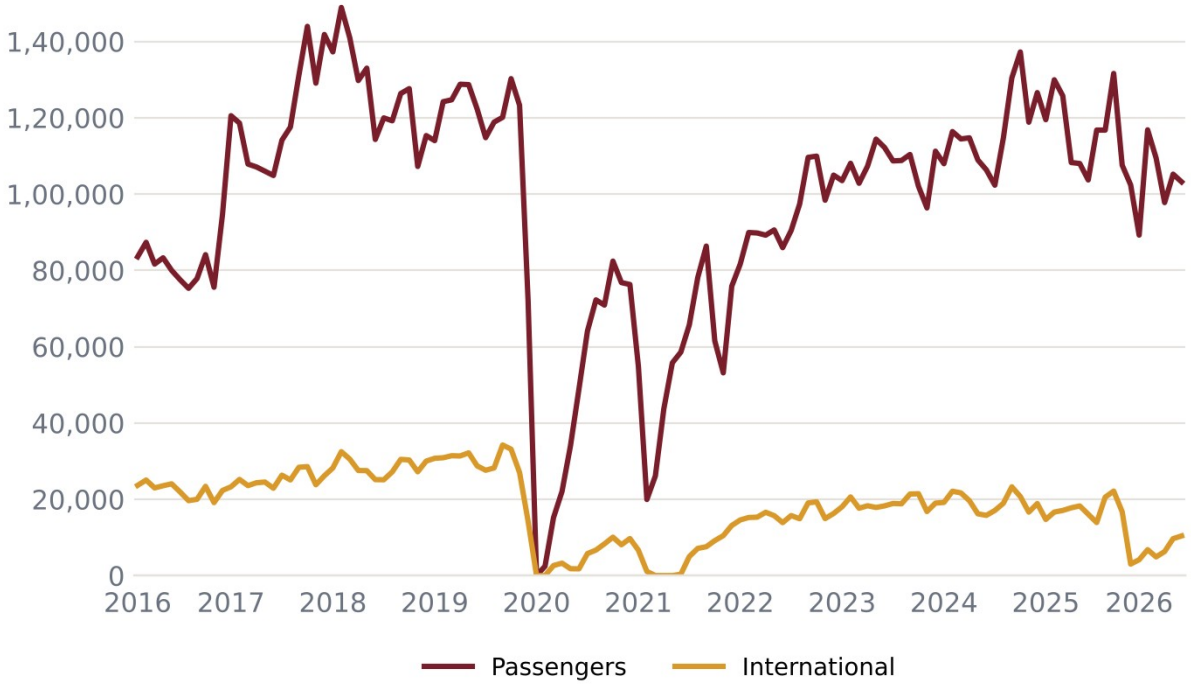
Falling down the national table

Airport	FY 2018-19	FY 2025-26	Change	Rank 18-19	Rank 25-26
Thiruvananthapuram (TRV)	44,34,459	46,94,206	+5.9%	#14	#16
Kozhikode (CCJ)	33,60,847	38,55,618	+14.7%	#17	#21
Coimbatore (CJB)	30,00,882	34,20,745	+14.0%	#19	#23
Mangaluru (IXE)	22,40,664	25,48,088	+13.7%	#27	#30
Tiruchirappalli (TRZ)	15,78,831	22,21,024	+40.7%	#31	#31
Madurai (IXM)	**15,20,016**	**13,88,062**	**-8.7%**	**#32**	**#40**

- In FY 2018-19 Madurai (15,20,016) and Trichy (15,78,831) were neck and neck; by FY 2025-26 Trichy handled 8,32,962 more passengers a year.

Source: AAI annual figures as tabulated on Wikipedia 'List of busiest airports in India' (verify before quoting)

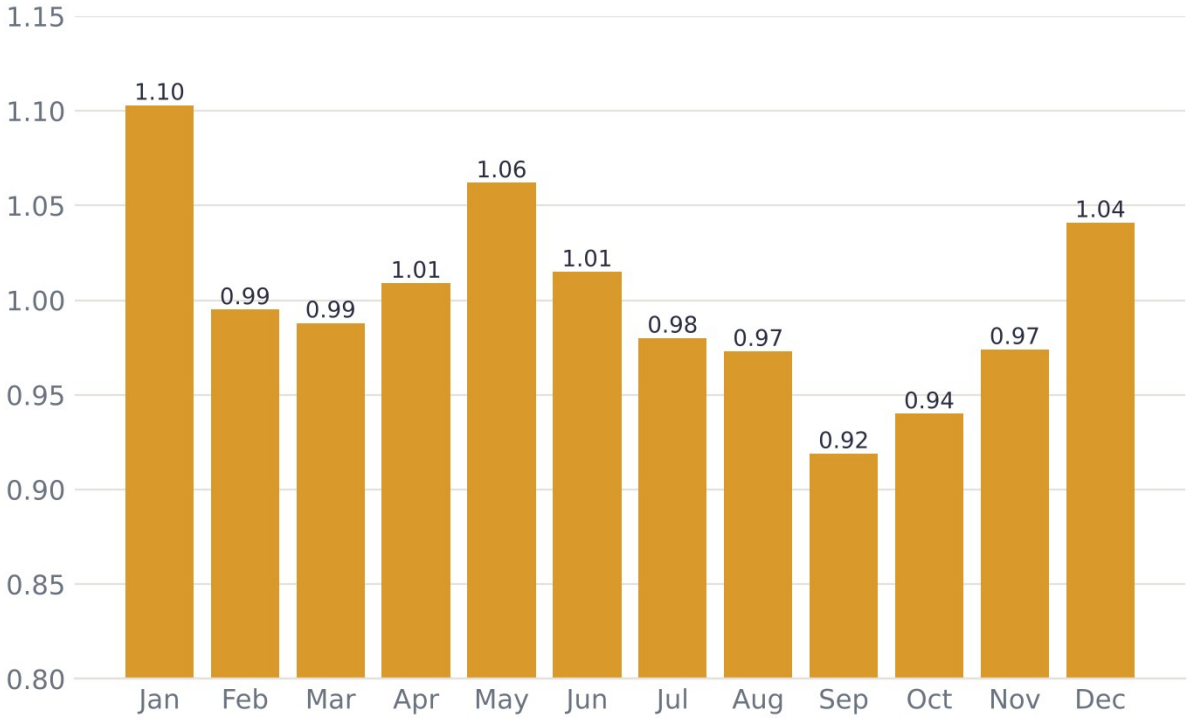
Month by month since 2016



- Busiest month on record: May 18 (1,48,929)
- Mar 2020 – mid 2022: COVID collapse and slow recovery
- From Mar 2026: Gulf flights suspended – international traffic drops to a fraction
- Latest: Sep 26 1,03,203 passengers

Source: AAI monthly Traffic News (aai.aero), compiled by the IXM Pulse tracker

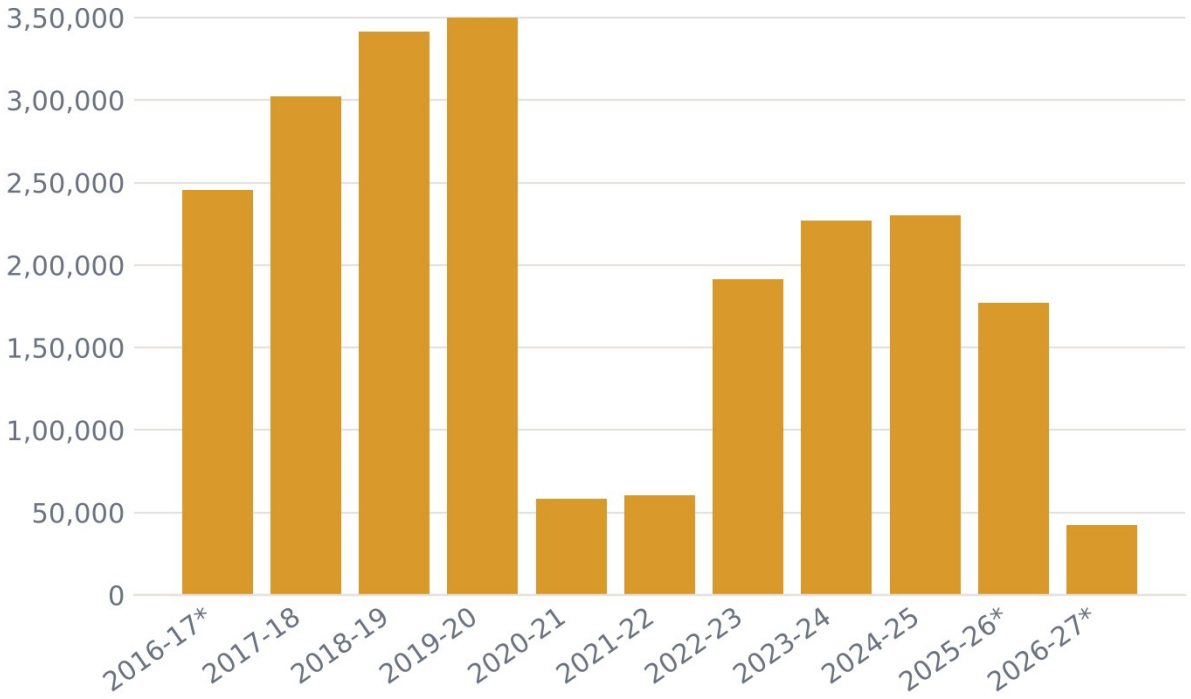
A festival and holiday rhythm airlines can plan around



- 1.00 = an average month
- Peaks: Jan 1.10, May 1.06, Dec 1.04 – in line with Pongal, summer and year-end holidays (our interpretation of the timing)
- Lows: Oct 0.94, Sep 0.92
- Peak months run about 15–20% above the quietest – a case for seasonal extra flights

Source: AAI monthly Traffic News (aai.aero), compiled by the IXM Pulse tracker (seasonal model, COVID months excluded)

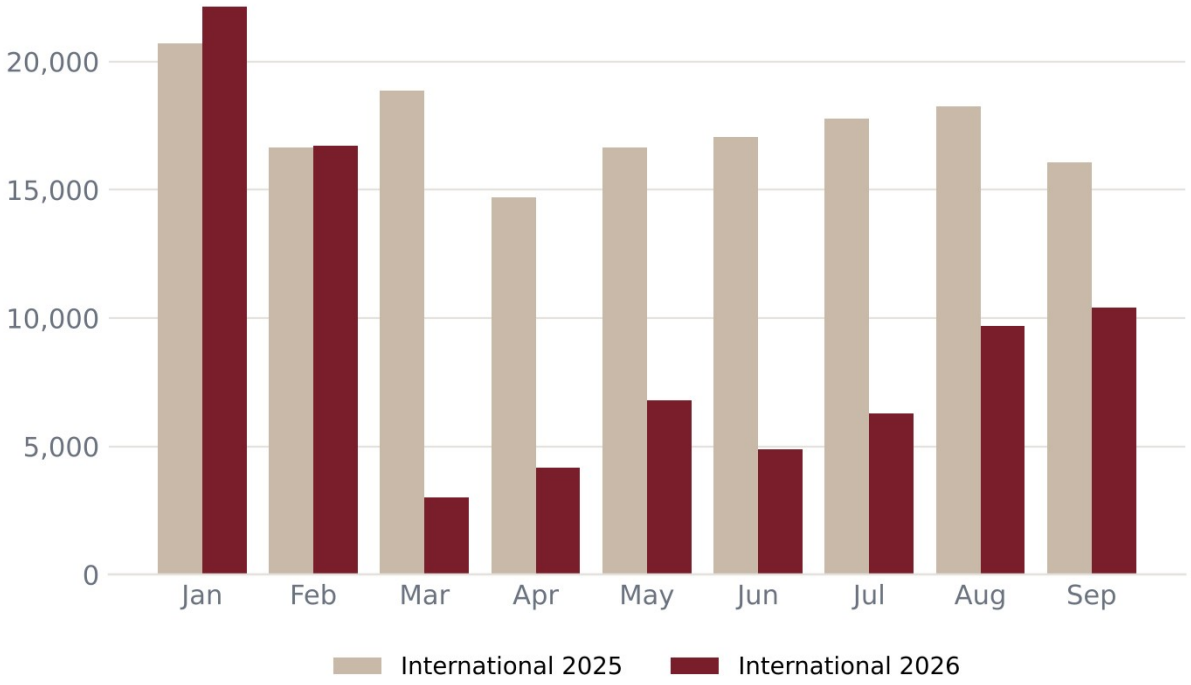
International travel: once a quarter of all passengers



- International share: 24.6% in FY19-20 → 16.4% in FY24-25 → 13.9% in FY25-26*
- Peak international year: FY 2019-20 (3,49,816)
- FY 2024-25: 2,30,080 – still 34% below peak
- Madurai serves a large Gulf & South-East Asian diaspora market – the biggest growth lever

Source: AAI monthly Traffic News (aai.aero), compiled by the IXM Pulse tracker

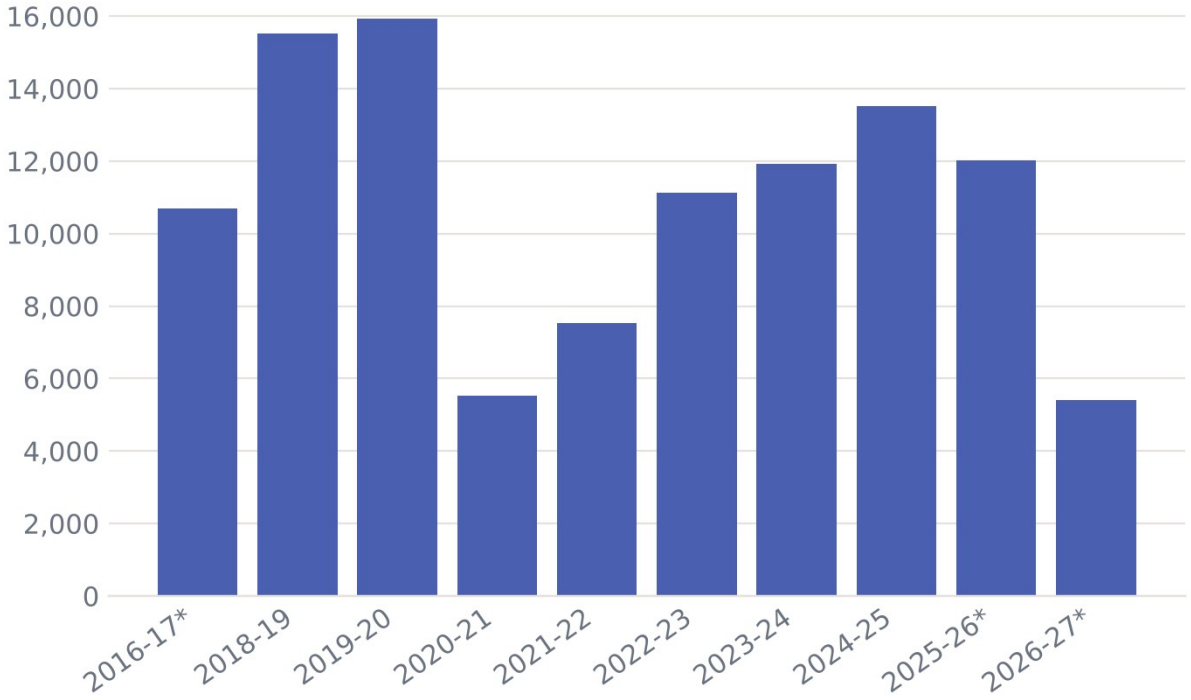
2026: the Gulf suspension – and a weak domestic first half



- Dubai & Abu Dhabi flights suspended from end-Feb 2026 (Gulf conflict); resumption from 14 Aug
- Mar–Jul 2026: about 59,923 fewer international passengers than a year earlier
- Domestic was also down 2.9–18.8% year on year in Jan–Jun 2026
- Latest month: domestic +5.9% and international -35.4% in Sep 26

Source: AAI monthly Traffic News (aai.aero), compiled by the IXM Pulse tracker; DT Next, 26 Jun 2026

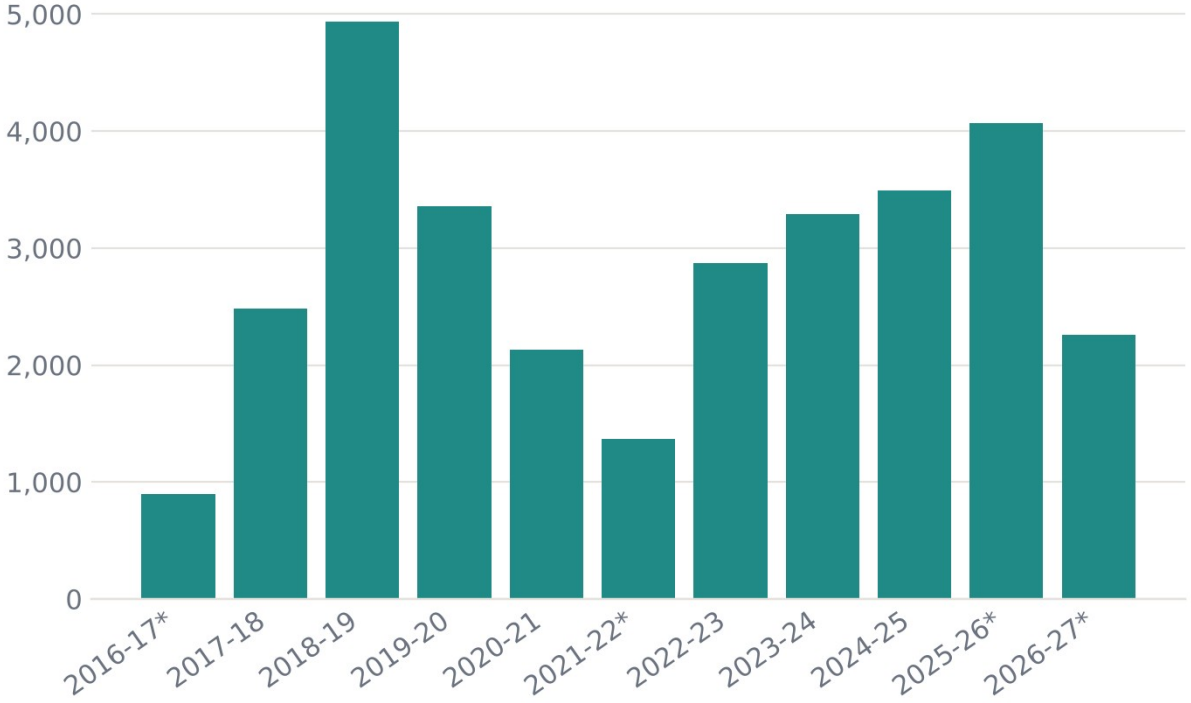
Fewer flights, fuller flights



- Movements peaked at 15,925 in FY19-20; 13,513 in FY24-25
- Passengers per movement: FY23-24: 108, FY24-25: 104, FY25-26: 106, FY26-27: 115 (FY19-20: 89)
- More passengers per movement means fuller and/or larger aircraft – AAI does not publish seats, so the split is not known. Fewer movements does mean fewer choices of flight times

Source: AAI monthly Traffic News (aai.aero), compiled by the IXM Pulse tracker

Air cargo: climbing back towards its 2018-19 peak



- Cargo is reported every month since 2016; it jumped in FY17-18 and peaked at 4,934 t in FY 2018-19 (confirmed by AAI's revised figures)
- FY 2024-25: 3,494 t; FY 2025-26: 4,070 t in 11 months
- FY 2026-27 so far: 2,260 t in 6 months
- Cargo is growing while passengers stagnate. AAI does not split belly-hold and freighter cargo, so the driver of growth cannot be told from this data

Source: AAI monthly Traffic News (aai.aero), compiled by the IXM Pulse tracker

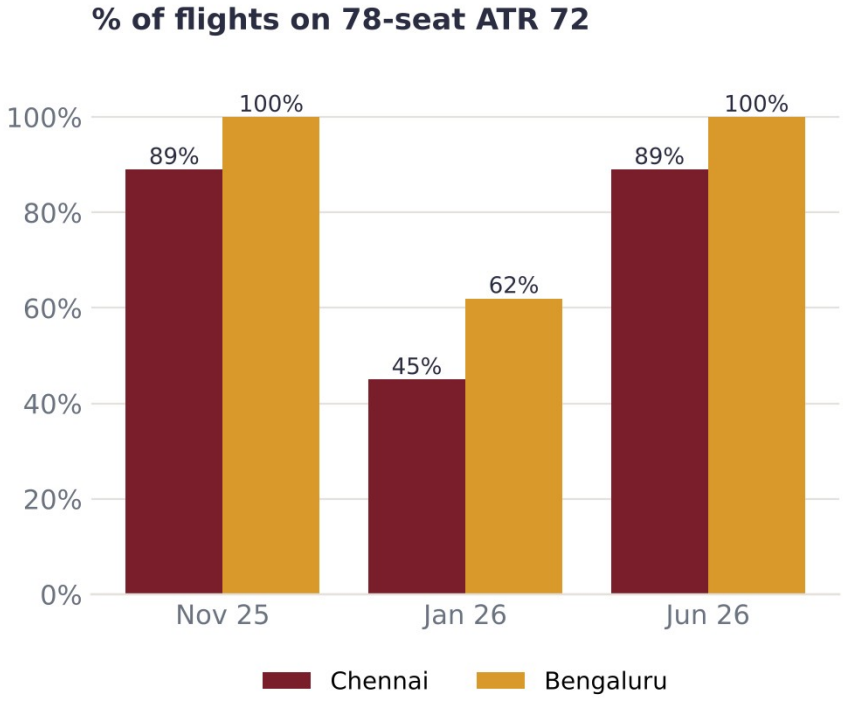
The network today: few destinations, one dominant airline

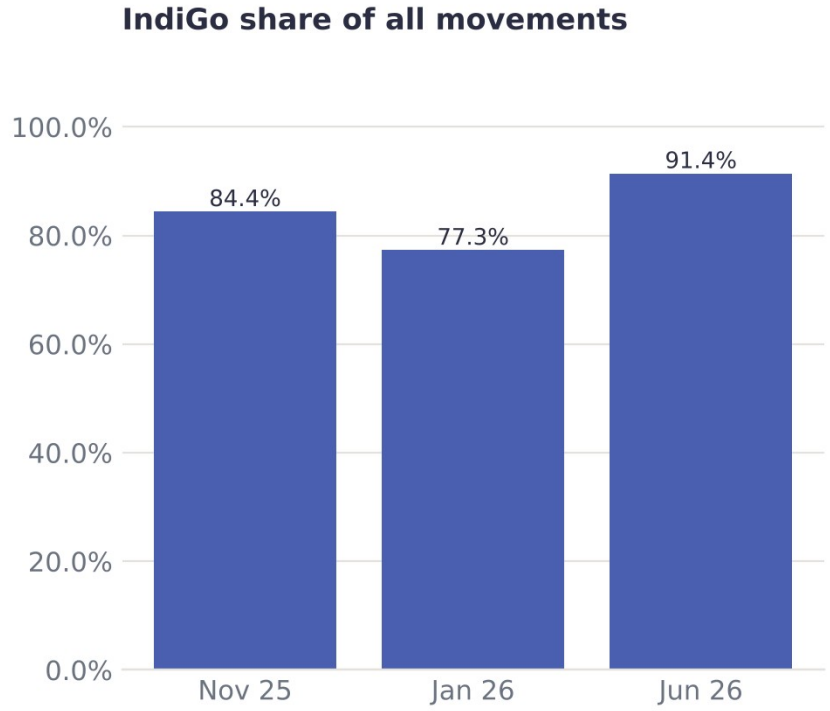
Destination	Dep/week Nov 25	Dep/week Jan 26	Dep/week Jun 26	Airlines (Jun 26)
Chennai	63	29.8	63	Air India, IndiGo
Bengaluru	20.1	14	31.5	IndiGo
Hyderabad	14.2	14	10.5	IndiGo
New Delhi	7	7	7	IndiGo
Dubai ✈	7	7	–	suspended
Mumbai	7	7	7	IndiGo
Colombo ✈	5.6	5.9	4.2	SriLankan
Abu Dhabi ✈	2.8	2.9	–	suspended
Navi Mumbai	–	–	6.8	IndiGo

✈ international. Departures per week averaged over the month; return flights not counted twice.

Source: AeroDataBox flight records collected by the IXM Pulse tracker

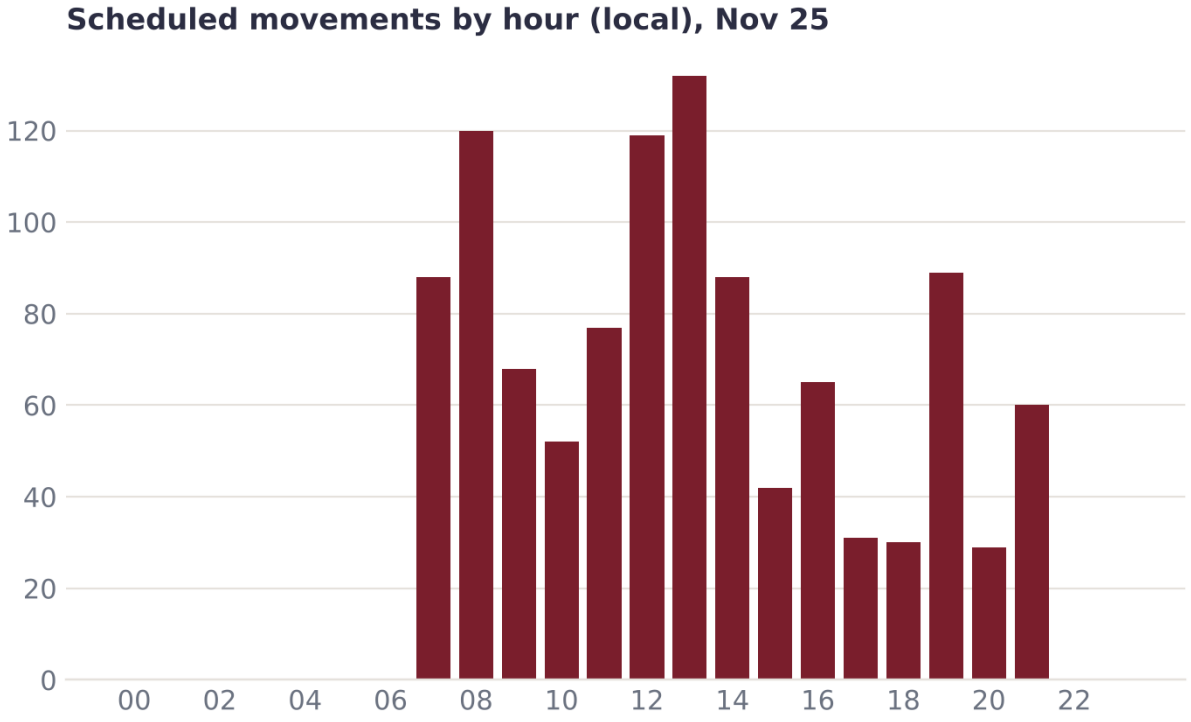
Turboprops on busy routes, one airline dominates





Source: AeroDataBox flight records collected by the IXM Pulse tracker

Daytime only: no scheduled flights 22:00–06:00



- 24-hour operations started in Oct 2024 (reported)
- Night movements (22:00–06:00): Nov 25 0, Jan 26 0, Jun 26 0
- Night slots let airlines use aircraft that fly elsewhere by day and suit onward Gulf connections – unused night capacity is an opportunity (rationale, not measured here)

Source: AeroDataBox flight records collected by the IXM Pulse tracker

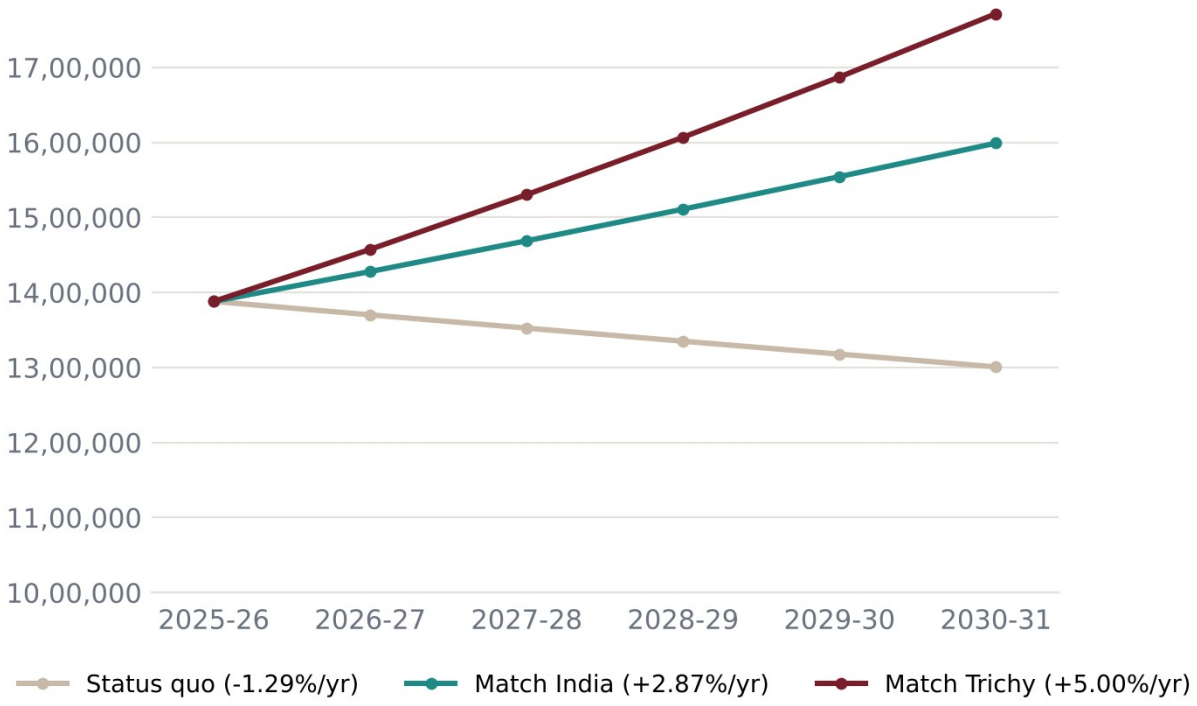
Infrastructure: terminal headroom, runway limits

48%	2,285 m	543 / 653	Mar 2026
terminal capacity used	runway today	acres handed over	international airport status
1.39M of 2.9M passengers a year	3,810 m planned (wide-body)	Aug 2025 – no completion date	Union Cabinet approval

- Busiest hour in the flight data: 4.4–5.0 movements a day on average. The terminal is not the bottleneck this decade: even the fastest what-if path (slide 17) reaches about 61% of capacity by FY 2030-31.
- The runway is: wide-body aircraft (A330/B777) need the 3,810 m extension – essential for long-haul and heavy cargo.
- Madurai has been outside bilateral air service agreements, which kept foreign airlines away – the new international status is the moment to change this.

Source: Swarajya 22 Aug 2025; Wikipedia 'Madurai Airport'; Mysuru Infra Hub 5 Oct 2024

Outlook: decisions, not destiny



- What-if paths from the FY 2025-26 published total, using growth rates actually observed FY18-19→FY25-26:
- Status quo: 13.0 lakh by FY 2030-31
- Match India: 16.0 lakh by FY 2030-31
- Match Trichy: 17.7 lakh by FY 2030-31
- Statistical 12-month forecast (Oct 26–Sep 27): about 13.4 lakh (backtest error 9.1%)

Source: AAI monthly Traffic News (aai.aero), compiled by the IXM Pulse tracker; scenario growth rates from AAI annual figures

What Madurai should ask for (1/3)

#	Ask	Evidence	To whom	Priority
1	**Restore Gulf services in full and add Sharjah, Muscat, Kuwait and Doha**	International passengers fell by about 59,923 in Mar–Jul 2026 vs the same months of 2025 during the Gulf suspension; international share was 22.5% in FY18-19	SpiceJet (Dubai) and IndiGo (Abu Dhabi), which flew these before the suspension; other Indian and Gulf carriers; MoCA	**High**
2	**Use the new international status: seek point-of-call rights for foreign carriers (Gulf, Sri Lanka, Malaysia, Singapore)**	International status approved Mar 2026; Madurai was outside bilateral agreements, which kept foreign airlines away	MoCA, Ministry of External Affairs, State Government	**High**
3	**Upgauge Chennai and Bengaluru from ATR 72 turboprops to A320-family jets**	Share of flights on 78-seat ATR 72s – 2025-11: Chennai 89% (63.0 dep/wk), Bengaluru 100% (20.1 dep/wk); 2026-01: Chennai 45% (29.8 dep/wk), Bengaluru 62% (14.0 dep/wk); 2026-06: Chennai 89% (63.0 dep/wk), Bengaluru 100% (31.5 dep/wk)	IndiGo, Air India	**High**

Source: Evidence computed from AAI and AeroDataBox data in this review; context sources listed in the Excel workbook

What Madurai should ask for (2/3)

#	Ask	Evidence	To whom	Priority
4	**Use the 24-hour licence: night slots for international and long domestic flights**	0 scheduled movements between 22:00 and 06:00 across 3 complete months of flight data (2025-11, 2026-01, 2026-06), although 24-hour operations began in Oct 2024	AAI Madurai, airlines	**Medium**
5	**Attract a second large domestic airline to reduce dependence on one carrier**	IndiGo share of movements – 2025-11: 84.4%; 2026-01: 77.3%; 2026-06: 91.4%	Air India group, Akasa Air, State Government (incentives)	**Medium**
6	**Test candidate new direct routes to unserved metros, e.g. Kolkata, Pune, Ahmedabad (hypotheses – demand not shown by this data)**	8 regular destinations in 2026-01; Madurai fell from rank 32 to 40 among Indian airports between FY18-19 and FY25-26	Airlines, State Government (viability-gap / UDAN-type support)	**Medium**

Source: Evidence computed from AAI and AeroDataBox data in this review; context sources listed in the Excel workbook

What Madurai should ask for (3/3)

#	Ask	Evidence	To whom	Priority
7	**Complete the remaining land handover and fix a timeline for the 3,810 m runway**	109.94 of 653.35 acres pending (Aug 2025); wide-body capability needed for long-haul and heavy cargo	State Government, AAI	Medium
8	**Grow air cargo: export facilitation for perishables and regional produce**	Cargo 4,070 t in 11 months of FY25-26 vs 3,494 t in all of FY24-25, while passengers fell	AAI Cargo Logistics, Customs, State export agencies	Medium
9	**Publish route-level origin–destination data so routes can be planned on evidence**	Only monthly airport totals are public; route-level demand is unknown	DGCA, AAI	Low

Source: Evidence computed from AAI and AeroDataBox data in this review; context sources listed in the Excel workbook

Opportunities to create

Diaspora corridors

Gulf, Singapore, Malaysia and Sri Lanka routes – international was 21–25% of traffic before COVID (AAI). Target: restore and exceed FY19-20's 3,49,816 international passengers.

Heritage & pilgrim gateway

Meenakshi Amman Temple, Rameswaram and Kodaikanal are within reach; the Dec–Jan peaks could support seasonal and charter flights. (Qualitative – no visitor data in this review.)

Air cargo from the south

Cargo grew while passengers stalled. International status plus customs and cold-chain facilities can serve agricultural and regional exporters.

Night slots & based aircraft

Zero scheduled night movements despite 24-hour operations. An airline basing aircraft overnight in Madurai enables early departures and late returns.

Next steps and limits of this review

- Share this evidence with AAI Madurai, the Ministry of Civil Aviation, the State Government and airlines; track progress monthly on the IXM Pulse dashboard.
- Ask DGCA/AAI for route-level origin–destination data – it would turn route proposals from hypotheses into business cases.
- Limits: AAI months 2016-10 and 2025-11 not available; flight-level detail covers 95 days (AeroDataBox keeps 365 days of history); peer figures are AAI totals via Wikipedia, without a domestic/international split.
- Not analysed (no data here): fares, catchment and leakage to Trichy or other airports, road and rail competition, and airline-by-airline history before Nov 2025 – so the causes of the fall since FY18-19 are not proven by this review.
- Scenarios are illustrative what-ifs using observed growth rates; the 12-month forecast is a statistical model, not an official projection.
- Dashboard: jarunprasath.github.io/madurai-airport-tracker